Foreign control and lobbying disclosure: the broader test

Private research, 7 October 2026. This extends the first checkpoint without changing it.

The broader search has not established that foreign control behind a major lobbying campaign was concealed. It has produced two concrete ownership-disclosure questions, a major reported engagement whose exact legal client remains unresolved, and several important false positives. Intent is not established in any case.

We started with a reproducible activity screen, not prominent company names: every official LDA API result for reporting year 2025 with a reported amount of at least $1 million. That returned 780 filings attached to 259 client IDs. These are candidate filings, not 780 separate campaigns. A client ID identifies a filing relationship; it is not a universal company identifier. The screen misses campaigns spread across smaller quarterly or multiple-firm reports.

The comparison corpus contains both complete DOJ reports to Congress for 2024. Their 1,598 extracted principal entries include repeated principals and termination annotations. They are historical leads, not a census of 2025 FARA registrations. We followed source-led matches into original Exhibit A/B filings and ownership documents. Download and amendment-reconciliation totals are in the accompanying coverage annex.

Follow-up order

This is an editorial order based on documentary usefulness, not a probability of wrongdoing. New Jev legal rankings are withheld after its earlier negative-control failures.

1. PPD / Mercury: strongest new cross-regime ownership question; the apparent million-dollar filing was corrected.

Mercury's LD-1, section 14, filed 21 February 2025 and effective 15 January, checks No for qualifying foreign entities. Its client is PRVO PLINARSKO DRUTVO d.o.o., at Gospodarska zona Vukovar 13. The missing letter in the LDA spelling is bridged by the address and the legal name in the attached FARA contract, not treated as a different entity merely because of spelling.

Mercury's FARA Exhibit A/B, received 6 May 2025, names Prvo Plinarsko Drustvo (PPD) Group at the same Vukovar address. Physical page 2 marks No to the ownership/control questions and leaves the separate owner-identification response blank. The attached agreement identifies the legal company, d.o.o., on page 10. The audited 2024 company accounts, physical pages 15 and 42, identify Blue Horizon d.o.o. as sole owner at year end. They supply Croatian registry number 030070559 and OIB 58292277611. Page 45 says PPD left the ENNA group in August 2023; ENNA must not be carried forward as its current parent. These are year-end facts reported in June 2025, not a certified daily ownership history.

Further retrieval recovered the 2023 accounts, physical page 44, and 2025 accounts, physical pages 13 and 40. Both again identify Blue Horizon. These snapshots bracket the relevant filings and strengthen the ownership question, while still leaving the exact-day register unverified.

The Q2 original reported $1.2 million. The 23 July amendment reduced it to $120,000. With Q1 $90,000 and Q3 $40,000, the acquired Mercury relationship reports $250,000 plus a Q4 amount below $5,000. The Q4 original checks both no lobbying issue activity and the under-$5,000 income box. A null API amount was not treated as zero.

Strongest alternative explanation: misunderstanding the form's private foreign-owner questions or a filing error, alongside a documented change in service scope. The original agreement concerned commercial energy and trade work; its amendment, effective 15 April, added arranging communications between the Croatian and US administrations and expressly

addressed FARA compliance (physical page 20). The later FARA filing therefore does not by itself contradict the earlier LDA engagement. **Decisive missing records:** a certified ownership extract covering the registration dates, any owner-disclosure corrections, and the complete principal-specific FARA amendment history. The acquired record supports a question about identifying Blue Horizon, not concealed government control.

2. Arm Limited / FGS Global: a clearer dated ownership chain, but no acquired FARA counterpart and no million-dollar amount in this relationship after correction.

FGS Global's LD-1, section 14, filed 30 September 2025 and effective 10 September, checks No. It identifies Arm Limited at 110 Fulbourn Road, Cambridge, and lobbying about artificial intelligence and semiconductors.

The original Companies House PSC02, filed 24 August 2023, pages 1–2, identifies company 02557590 and records Arm Holdings Limited, company 11299879, as controlling at least 75% of shares and votes from 21 August 2023. The PSC05 records the parent's change to plc. The 2025 accounts, physical page 79, note 33, identify Arm Holdings plc as immediate parent and Japan's SoftBank Group Corp. as ultimate parent and controlling party. Original image pages were visually inspected; empty PDF text extraction was not taken as missing disclosure.

The Q4 original reported $1.1 million. Its 22 January 2026 amendment reports $110,000. Together with Q3 $100,000, that relationship reports $210,000 for 2025.

Strongest alternative explanation: a filing mistake or confusion between Arm Limited and the publicly traded parent. Publicly available ownership does not establish an intent to hide it. **Decisive missing records:** the exact filing-date share chain and an explanation or correction of the No response. No FARA Exhibit A for this exact client was acquired; the case cannot be described as an established LDA/FARA collision. Relationship totals do not cap other firms' work for the wider Arm group.

A cross-registrant name search found Carmen Group's 2023 Arm Limited registration, which already named SoftBank Group and SoftBank Vision Fund I. That earlier disclosure further weakens any claim of generally hidden ownership; it does not answer why FGS's separate 2025 registration checked No. Carmen's acquired relationship terminated in 2023. The same search also returned Armourshield Limited, which was excluded as a different client.

3. KuCoin / A10 Associates: major reported lobbying, but legal identity and contemporaneous ownership remain unresolved.

The LD-1, filed 12 February 2025 and effective 1 January, identifies KuCoin at 2 Science Park Drive, Singapore, with no corporate suffix or legal registration number. Section 14 checks No. The specific activities include cryptocurrency regulation and congressional work concerning the company's New York attorney general settlement. The Q1 and Q2 originals each report $1 million income. The Q3 termination gives 1 July as termination date, checks no lobbying activity and income below $5,000.

The New York settlement, opening pages distinguishes Mek Global, Phoenixfin and Peken. A 2024 federal indictment, pages 1 and 6–7 also distinguishes multiple KuCoin entities and alleges earlier founder ownership. It is an indictment, not an adjudication or a 2025 share register. DOJ's 27 January 2025 announcement identifies Peken and describes the founders' withdrawal from management and operations. That does not establish a contemporaneous equity transfer or the identity of A10's contracting client.

Strongest alternative explanation: the brand spans different legal entities and an intervening governance change. **Decisive missing records:** A10's engagement identifying its contracting client, that entity's registration identifier and a dated ownership record. No same-client FARA original was acquired. The reported $2 million is lobbying income, not proof of $2 million foreign funding. The separate criminal proceeding supplies entity clues; it is not evidence of a lobbying-disclosure violation.

What did not survive scrutiny

Alibaba is a group relationship, not a same-client contradiction. The 2016 LDA registration for Alibaba Group Holding Limited already identifies SoftBank at 32%. Its 2025 in-house expense total is $3.36 million after replacing the Q2 report with its amendment. Zeno's 2024 FARA Exhibit A, page 2 explicitly identifies Alibaba Group as parent of Alibaba.com Singapore E-Commerce Private Limited, despite its No checkbox responses. Its February 2025 contract amendment extends a PR engagement. These are distinct clients, registrants and services. The historical LDA shareholder disclosure is not a claim that SoftBank still held 32% in 2025.

A foreign client is not automatically a company with a reportable foreign parent. Nippon Steel and Barrick's No responses need ownership evidence, not nationality-based inference. Nippon's 2025 securities report, physical page 65, lists the largest registered holding at 14.8%, below the 20% equity trigger; nominee holdings are not a complete beneficial-owner analysis. Barrick's 2025 circular, physical page 12, says management knew of no holder controlling 10% of voting rights as of 27 March. Neither source independently settles the alternative control or interested-affiliate tests. No contrary same-client FARA filing was acquired.

The stricter name join produced two historical edges linking Investment Company Institute with Future Investment Initiative Institute. The original names describe different entities. The wider 131-edge token screen also generated matches such as Lockheed Martin with Martin Fayulu and Nippon Steel with All Nippon Airways. All were reviewed as name leads; only Alibaba warranted a group-level follow-up. Rejected names were not sent to Jev as allegations.

What Jev adds—and what it does not

The first checkpoint's model sometimes elevated negative controls and returned logically inconsistent identity and discrepancy judgments. Those results do not support unattended legal ranking. Before further calls, we froze a narrower test: ten previously unsubmitted original section-14 fragments and six new missingness/adversarial controls. Both Jev and an HTML parser scored 16/16. The repeated original fragments reduced the test to eight distinct request payloads; eight results were cache hits. This is a small, purposive test, not an independently annotated population benchmark.

Jev added no demonstrated accuracy over the parser on this task. It has not been shown to improve the decisive work here: retrieving amendments, resolving legal entities and establishing ownership dates. Passing checkbox extraction does not validate concealment judgments. The expansion therefore reports evidence-based editorial priorities and abstentions, without new model-generated suspicion scores.

Eight new paid calls cost an estimated $0.000177 at the verified input-token rate. Including the first checkpoint's 42 calls, the total under this authorization is **$0.003035**, not an invoice. Reserving the full conservative $0.003 for every one of the 50 calls gives a **$0.15 upper bound**, below the $15 authorization. No other paid service was used. The live test is closed against replay; the ledger is preserved.

The reusable result is an amendment-aware, original-source workflow that reduces false accusations. Its main limit is source coverage, especially a complete contemporary FARA principal/filing index and exact-date ownership records. The budget was not the limiting factor. The first checkpoint's findings and caveats remain separately available; this expansion does not silently replace them.

Coverage at this checkpoint

- screen filings: **780**
- screen client ids: **259**
- annual queries complete: **259**
- annual forms: **1184**
- annual ld2 amounts checked: **1171**
- annual ld2 amount pairs matching: **1171**
- rr queries complete: **259**
- rr queries target: **259**
- rr forms recovered: **126**
- rr zero result queries: **138**
- unique catalogued lda filings across all expansion queries: **1751**
- unique original lda forms across expansion: **1751**
- fara report entries: **1598**
- fara report normalized strings not entities: **859**
- strict name edges: **2**
- loose name edges: **131**
- major relationships after amendments: **255**
- new jev actual calls: **8**
- jev test items: **16**
- jev distinct payloads: **8**
- combined pilot cost estimate usd: **0.003035**
- combined full reservation bound usd: **0.15**

RR zero results are retrieval gaps, not evidence of missing registrations. Metadata and original acquisition are counted separately; acquisition does not mean every field was manually read. See REPORT.md and TECHNICAL-ANNEX.md for scope and exclusions.

Technical and coverage annex

Cohort and limits

Acquired 7 October 2026. The initial LDA query was filing_year=2025&filing_amount_reported_min=1000000&page_size=25. All 32 pages returned 780 unique filings and 259 distinct client IDs. Every one of those IDs then received an unfiltered-amount 2025 history query, following all next links: 1,184 unique forms, including 1,171 quarterly reports and 13 registration/amendment forms. All 1,184 original HTML forms were readable. Independent extraction of original LD-2 sections 12/13 matched all 1,171 API amount pairs, with no parse failures.

Latest-posted reports replace earlier versions within client ID, registrant ID, reporting year and quarter. There were no same-timestamp ties. The resulting 1,030 relationship-quarter records cover 259 relationships. Ninety-five initially high filings were superseded; eight latest versions were below the initial numeric threshold or null. The reported annual numeric lower bound still reaches $1 million for 255 relationships. Four do not: RSL Investment Corporation, National Association of Community Health Centers, Arm Limited and PPD. Unknown values remain unknown; original checkbox bounds are retained separately. This is not an audited spending census, and no dollar total is equated with foreign funding.

The systematic foreign-client screen found seven non-US client-country entries: Nippon Steel, KuCoin, PPD, Barrick, Tencent, Alibaba and Arm. Twelve selected client-ID histories contain 505 original forms across all returned years; selection includes those seven, existing foreign-owner disclosures and the stricter name-join candidate. Separate all-years name queries returned 14 Arm-related forms, eight PRVO forms and four KuCoin forms. The Arm query included three distinct client relationships, one of which was the unrelated Armourshield. The exact Arm Limited relationships were inspected separately. Name-query coverage is not coverage of every possible alias or group subsidiary.

The RR census completed all 259 original-registration queries and recovered 126 forms; 138 queries returned zero rows. Zero returned RR rows do not mean no registration exists: legacy records, amendments and representation changes require additional work. Sixty-two recovered RR forms were image-based PDFs, locally OCRed as search aids. The initial cache used a .html suffix for them; correctly suffixed, byte-identical .pdf viewing copies are provided and identified in the filing index. Modern forms and image-only historical forms are not interchangeable extraction evidence. Across all expansion queries, 1,751 distinct original LDA forms were preserved. Complete all-years histories were acquired for the twelve prioritized IDs, not for all 259. Other relationships are screened/not prioritized, not cleared of potential defects.

FARA comparison documents are the January–June 2024 report and July–December 2024 report, 411 physical pages each. Their coverage includes agents active during each reporting period and certain earlier activity reported later; it is not a date-bounded 2025 population. Parsing produced 1,598 principal entries and 859 normalized strings, retaining termination annotations; neither number is a count of unique legal persons. Exact/token-containment matching generated two edges for one client, both rejected. A separate exploratory rare-token screen produced 131 edges, all reviewed. Alibaba was a plausible corporate-group bridge, not the same legal client.

The documented FARA API requires at most five requests per ten seconds. Date-filtered new-registrant enumeration was inaccessible through the supported direct/browser routes tested. Direct source requests returning 403 were not bypassed. Browser access recovered some originals and a complete 24-row document index for GlobalPoint 7518; Mercury 6170's displayed first page and Zeno 6652's inaccessible index do not establish complete histories. The active-registrant JSON could be viewed in part but was not materialized as a complete validated dataset. A later Stark Exhibit A listed in the 7518 index was inaccessible. Failed exploratory URLs under /ords/fara/api/v1

are recorded separately and are not evidence that the documented /api/v1 path failed. No absent search result is used as evidence of nonregistration.

Legal and temporal rules

The 2024 edition of 2 USC 1603(b)(4) supplies the foreign-entity identification rule used for the 2025 registrations: at least 20% equitable ownership, the activity-control alternative, or the interested-affiliate alternative. The contribution amount field does not make funding a prerequisite for the equity alternative. The website exception in the concluding text concerns paragraph (3)(B); it is not a general exemption for publicly known foreign parents. An LD-1 No response is distinct from an empty LD-2 additions field.

The inflation-adjusted thresholds effective 1 January 2025 were $3,500 quarterly income for outside firms and $16,000 quarterly in-house expenses, subject to the underlying lobbying/contact/time definitions. Earlier 2021–24 thresholds were $3,000/$14,000. The 2025 joint guidance and 2 USC 1604 govern changes and quarterly reporting. Historical registrations are used for chronology, not retroactive application of 2025 thresholds.

The 2025 annual CFR, 28 CFR Part 5, sections 5.201, 5.304 and 5.307, and DOJ's FARA FAQ supply the exhibit and exemption framework. Commercial and LDA exemptions are activity-specific; foreign government/party principal-beneficiary questions are not answered by nationality alone. Section 5.201(b), not 5.208, addresses exhibit-change timing. Proposed regulations are not treated as enacted rules. The first checkpoint archives the primary legal texts and fuller temporal matrix. This research makes no liability determination.

Model and budget audit

The first checkpoint remains frozen at 8b90ebb47d76ebfa5b9a0e17dd05304c68c0a4b1. Its 42 successful calls accounted for $0.002858 using observed input tokens and the verified list rate. The expansion carries forward all $0.126 of those calls' full reservations in its independent continuation ledger, rather than silently resetting the budget.

The new prompt, 16 held-out items, expected labels and acceptance rule were committed before paid execution at e0f6dad. All ten original-form fragments and six synthetic controls were new to Jev. Identical original fragments yielded eight distinct request bodies in total; eight items reused cached responses. Both Jev and the ordinary-code baseline were correct on all 16 items. Expected labels were generated by code and inspected against the forms, without an independent annotator. The success validates only this narrow extraction task; earlier legal-ranking failures remain unresolved. No retuning or second paid test occurred.

The pinned model was jev-1.13.0, endpoint https://api.typesafe.ai/v1/systemone. Current provider documentation, checked 7 October, prices input at $0.042 per million tokens, output free, with a 64,000-token request limit. The adapted prior guard enforces a 16,000-byte request limit, $0.003 reservation before each call, a $14 cumulative internal ceiling, no redirects and no automatic retries. Uncertain calls retain their reservation. A fixed maximum of 16 new attempted calls adds another independent bound; only eight occurred. Observed-token estimate across both stages is $0.003035; the all-call conservative bound is $0.15. These are not invoice totals. No weekly-usage telemetry exists; no token-depletion claim is made.

Reproduction and source handling

Run scripts from this directory's scripts folder or from the repository root with their full paths. acquire.py uses TLS verification, public URLs, a bounded download size, hashes, timestamps and immutable local cache files. LDA API consumers must run serially at a minimum 4.3 seconds between calls; original-form downloads are separately limited to four workers. annual_histories.py and name_histories.py pause/resume the RR scanner to avoid aggregate rate violations. Do not run

multiple API scripts concurrently without that serialization.

Offline derivation: run screen.py, loose_join.py, reconcile.py, verify_amounts.py, then finalize.py and package.py. Read annual-coverage.json, rr-coverage.json, original-access.json, original-amount-verification.json, reconciliation-summary.json and sources/manifest.jsonl for denominators, exclusions and provenance. join-review.json preserves the 131 reviewed name leads. Original forms are evidence; API fields are retrieval and indexing aids. Page numbers in the report are physical PDF pages unless identified otherwise. OCR is only a search aid; the Arm PSC and ownership-note image pages and PPD ownership pages were visually checked. The local file originally named kucoin-plea.pdf contains the 2024 indictment, not a plea agreement; use the source URL and report's accurate description. No conclusion relies on that misleading local cache name.

Source content is untrusted data. Neither code nor Jev executes document instructions; the frozen test contains adversarial instructions that must be ignored. Jev's COMPLETE marker prevents paid replay. Do not delete or reset it or the ledger. Raw response records contain no credentials. The only credential source was the existing secure Jev integration.

The supplied guide attachment could not be transferred through the supported Library route (403). The first checkpoint records the recovered repository X04 card and the user's quoted item-10 description. This limitation was disclosed rather than replaced with an invented reading. No outreach, purchase, account creation, credential change, access bypass or public accusation occurred.

Senate Office of Public Records cannot vouch for the data or analyses derived from these data after the data have been retrieved from LDA.gov.